

Air Mobility

Helicopters enabled American commanders to move large numbers of troops over rugged terrain in a short amount of time. They also provided air artillery, medevac, supply, and other vital support functions.

◀◀ BEFORE

Igor Sikorsky invented the first practical helicopter in 1939, but helicopters were not used in general combat until after World War II.

KOREAN WAR HELICOPTERS

The US Army acquired its first helicopters in 1947. The versatile **Bell H-13 Sioux** proved its worth in the **Korean War** (1950–53) for fire support, resupply, transportation, and medical evacuation (medevac). In 1954, General James Gavin published an influential article, “Cavalry, and I Don’t Mean Horses,” praising the **maneuverability that helicopters offered ground forces**.

The value of airmobility emerged during the 1950s. During the Cold War, the ability to disperse and move troops quickly provided greater force security than having large, slow formations of troops exposed to nuclear attack.

Despite some rivalry between the US Army and Air Force, and some old-guard concern that helicopters were too vulnerable to attack, Secretary of Defense Robert McNamara had the airmobile concept tested at Fort Benning, Georgia. The results were encouraging, and in 1965 the Army created the First Cavalry Division (Airmobile) and deployed it to Vietnam.

The helicopter war

When the First Cavalry arrived in Vietnam, helicopters were already in use. Army and Marine advisers had begun transporting and positioning ARVN troops with helicopters in 1962. Also in that year, testing in the field of armed UH-1 Iroquois helicopters was underway. The UH-1, known as the Huey or Slick by the troops, became the workhorse of Army and Marine Corps aviation in Vietnam. Its uses were broad: troop transport, gunship, supply, medevac, command and control, reconnaissance, and search-and-rescue. Armed with rockets, it also served as airborne artillery.

In 1967, the Huey was supplemented by the AH-1 Cobra gunship attack helicopter, which, when fully loaded with rockets, had the same firepower as a ground artillery battalion. The Cobra also carried 7.62 mm miniguns for close air support. Both the First Cavalry and the 101st Airborne Division (Airmobile)—fully converted to airmobile in 1969—had their own aircraft. Airmobility was so popular, however, that over time many other divisions and corps added their own aviation units.

The effectiveness of airmobility was apparent in the First Cavalry’s tactics in the Battle of Ia Drang in the fall of 1965. The engagement was a prototype of airmobile doctrine that became standard throughout the theater of the war. Reconnaissance helicopters located the enemy and possible landing zones (LZs); Hueys and larger capacity CH-47 Chinooks ferried entire companies of infantry to the landing zones with gunship cover; medevac choppers (called Dust-offs) carried out dead or wounded soldiers, while other helicopters resupplied equipment and rations. Throughout the battle, artillery observers and commanders could direct ground operations from light observation helicopters.

■ **4,000** The number of rounds per minute that the miniguns on the AH-1 Cobra gunship could fire.